

Review of “Becoming Boundless: Indian Transnational Entrepreneurs in the Global Economy”

By Manashi Ray

Stanford University Press, 2026, 314 pages, price: \$130.00 (cloth) / \$32.00 (paper) / \$32.00. (eBook). <https://www.sup.org/books/sociology/becoming-boundless>

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The 297-page book consists of a long Introduction, four main chapters, and the conclusion. The author’s main argument in the book is that many post-1965 Indian immigrants to the United States have become cross-border infotech entrepreneurs, connecting the United States, India, and other countries, taking advantage of transnational global economy based on “the power of networks” since the early 1990s. The author of the book, Ray, is a first-generation Indian sociologist fluent in English and Hindi. She emphasizes the importance of networks for transnational businesses in the following paragraph:

“Put another way, the network perspective allows us to understand the connections between sending and receiving countries not as relationships of losers and winners, but as a global circulation of populations, skills, and labor that has changed the profiles, perceptions, and actions of contemporary migrants (p.19).

Ray’s book on Indian immigrants’ transnational business activities connecting with their homeland is not the first study of the kind. As she cited, several scholars, including Rori Varma and Alejandro Portes, had published several articles focusing on immigrants’ transnational business activities, connecting with their homelands. As a sociologist, she started her book project in 2011 and published it in 2026, spending 15 years for the book. If anyone intends to write a book focusing on immigrants’ transnational businesses with their home country, the US Indian immigrant group is ideal because many Indian immigrants are engaged in information technology. As an Indian-born sociologist, Ray is in an ideal position to write a book focusing on Indian transnational entrepreneurs.

Naturally, Ray reviewed the literature on traditional immigrant and ethnic businesses in the United States (pages 9–14). She has introduced several theories, including the theory of ethnic resources and ethnic networks, discrimination theory, and the theory of “social embeddedness.” She emphasizes that different immigrant and ethnic groups have dissimilar class and ethnic resources for entrepreneurship. She commented on Korean immigrants: “Korean entrepreneurs in the United States are extremely successful because in addition to their entrepreneurial skills, they tend to work in profitable enterprises” (p.10).

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However, I clarified Korean immigrant businesses in the United States in two of my important books, *Caught in the Middle: Korean Merchants in America's Multiethnic Cities* (1986) and *Ethnic Solidarity for Economic Survival: Korean Greengrocers in New York* (2008), both based on middleman minority theory. Historically, middleman minorities have delivered products made by white ruling people to black customers in racially divided societies. In the US Korean immigrants played the role of a middleman minority in the 1980s through 2010s. This interpretation of Korean immigrant merchants' role in New York and Los Angeles based on middleman minority theory seems to be more meaningful than Ray's speculation of Korean immigrant business owners' success.

Ray's review of the literature on transnational entrepreneurs (pp. 15–22) indicates that many articles, if not books, focusing on Asian immigrants' transnational entrepreneurship had been published in social science and business journals when she started her book project in 2011. Those references seem to have helped her make an outline of her book project in the beginning of her project.

For data sources, Ray adopted a qualitative approach using the life-story method, participant observations, and in-depth interviews (conducted in English and Hindi) with 60 Indians—45 men and 15 women—working in the infotech, professional services, manufacturing, and whole-sale/retail sectors, who lived in the United States or India at the time of their interviews (p. 54). She characterized her research method as binational and multi-sited ethnography. She also used secondary data sources from the 2020 US Decennial Census, 2020 Yearbook of Immigration Statistics, and several other public documents.

In addition, Ray emphasizes that she has advantages for research for this book as a first-generation Indian immigrant who has lived in India for many years and who can speak English, Hindi, and Bangla (p. 60). In Chapter One, she summarized the capitalist economic reforms in India, which trained many college students to immigrate to the United States. I consider Ray's research method and data sources as very relevant to achieving her objectives.

In Chapters 1 through 4, Ray has provided penetrating analyses of how Indian immigrants and their family members in the United States and India have started and managed transnational entrepreneurship. Since I do not have enough space, I have selected one important paragraph included in her Conclusion.

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I focused on three broad categories of TEs: migrant men TEs in the U.S., returnee men TEs in India, and women TEs in both countries. Though social capital is inherent within bonding and bridging ties, I found that the volume of different forms of resources (human, financial, and cultural capital) in networks and their usefulness and accessibility to TEs all mattered equally (p.192).

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As previously pointed out, many scholars have published journal articles focusing on transnational entrepreneurship. But no scholar has published a significant book focusing on this topic. No doubt, Manashi Ray's *Becoming Boundless* is the first significant book focusing on the important topic. The data sources she used are very relevant to the topic, and her analytic arguments given in four chapters are very strong. No doubt, she published an important book. The book could be a suitable textbook for both social science classes and business classes. If she had included several photos in the book, readers would have enjoyed reading it better.